

Describing Experiences - Persons vs. Events - "ed" vs. "ing"

A Quick-Reference Guide

For all general cases of description: When you tell a story (about an experience)... Basic Rules:

1) The focus should be the event (not you).	2) Describe the events and people using separate phrases. Some words and phrases, or grammar structures, are used just for people who are experiencing something, or just for events that are experienced.	3) Be wary that manipulating "grammar" logically can produce different real-life meanings.	4) Emergency and medical situations are an exception.
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Two Kinds of Mistakes

	Event Focus using "ing" [Good] (meaning and grammar are both correct)	vs.	Person focus using "ed" [Bad] (meaning is incorrect, but grammar is correct)	vs.	Confusing endings and meanings [Bad] (both meaning and grammar are both incorrect)
1	o The movie was exciting.	vs.	X I was excited.	vs.	X I was exciting.
2	o The trip was interesting.	vs.	X I was interested.	vs.	X I was interesting.
3	o The meeting was boring.	vs.	X I was bored.	vs.	X I was boring.
4	o Harvesting was tiring. v	vs.	X "I was tired."	vs.	X I was tiring

Two Different Meanings:

Nearly the same sentences referring to yourself or the experience may have different meanings.

Examples of correct grammar but a very different meaning:

	Topic of Confusion	Normal Statement	Normal Meaning	vs.	Strange Statement	Different Meaning
1	Did you perform or not?	The comics were very fun. The comics were greatly enjoyed.	The comics were good.	vs.	I was very fun. I was greatly enjoyed.	Some other person, enjoyed you => you made someone else happy.
2	Did you perform or not?	I was at a meeting all day, and the meeting was so exciting.	The meeting was good.	vs.	I was at a meeting all day and I was so exciting.	I was leading the meeting, performed well, and the audience was happy and excited.
3	"was interested"	The movie was interesting	good movie	vs.	I was interested in that movie...	1 = I want to ask you (a question) about the movie. 2 = Years ago I had a hobby similar to that movie.
4	excited = medical	The big fish at the aquarium was exciting.	It was exciting to see the big fish.	vs.	I was excited when I saw the big fish.	"I was excited" = clinical/medical CNS arousal, blood pressure (hypertension), anxiety attack.
5	Technical vs. Casual	Under the sea it is relaxing.	The sea is peaceful and friendly. I like the sea.	vs.	Under the sea I am relaxed.	You are describing muscle contraction in a sea location, not the feeling of the sea atmosphere.

Exceptions: In specific cases you can refer to yourself.

- Common expressions: e.g. Writing a thank you letter or email => Thank you, I had a good time. I had fun.
- Emergencies/Medical: e.g. I am on fire. I am anxious.